



Comments on Office of Science and Technology Policy RFI on the Development of an AI Action Plan

March 15, 2025

Workday appreciates the opportunity to provide input on the administration's forthcoming AI Action Plan to advance America's AI leadership, as directed by Executive Order 14179 (Removing Barriers to American Leadership in Artificial Intelligence).

Workday is the AI platform that helps organizations manage their most important assets – their people and money. The Workday platform is built with AI at the core to help customers elevate people, supercharge work, and move their business forever forward. Workday is used by more than 11,000 organizations around the world and across industries – from medium-sized businesses to more than 60% of the Fortune 500.

Our AI-powered applications help our customers drive smarter decisions, empower their employees and enable growth. We believe that AI should elevate human potential – not replace it. Our approach ensures that technology works alongside people, simplifying processes, enhancing decision-making, and improving workforce experiences.

A key part of the AI-driven transformation at work is the rise of AI agents, or, agentic AI. Agents are intelligent systems that perceive details from their environment, reason through next steps, and execute tasks to achieve specific goals. This technology moves beyond data analysis and predictions to autonomous execution, seamlessly integrating AI and people to handle complex processes.

Workday and our partners are building role-based agents that each contain a configurable set of skills that support people in their roles. As organizations adopt more and more AI agents, and as these agents become increasingly embedded in the workforce, businesses need a way to govern, optimize, and integrate them responsibly. We recently introduced the Workday Agent System of Record, which allows organizations to manage, orchestrate, and govern their fleet of AI agents alongside their incumbent workforce all on a single platform.

With advocacy teams in North America, Europe, and the Asia Pacific, Workday is proud of the constructive role we play in the public policy process. Consistent with our values, Workday advocates for policies that build trust, unlock human potential, and enable us to serve our customers. Workday has emerged as a leading voice on AI policy in the HR context and we are focused on ensuring the evolving AI policy landscape supports thoughtful AI governance approaches that are risk-based, leverage existing and workable accountability tools like impact assessments, clearly delineate responsibilities among those in the AI value chain, and support international harmonization.

If you have any questions or would like further information, please don't hesitate to contact Chandler Morse, VP, Corporate Affairs

Bolster U.S. AI Standards Leadership

The U.S. faces a unique opportunity to lead the world not only in AI technology, but in leading AI standards development as well. As with any technology, voluntary, consensus-based technical standards will play a critical role in underpinning AI innovation, helping American companies meet growing demands to demonstrate that their AI tools are built to widely-accepted criteria, and market their AI technology around the world. Technical standards for AI are particularly important to ensure global companies and small businesses alike can look to a single predictable and consistent framework. President Trump's 2019 Executive Order on Maintaining American Leadership in AI [recognized](#) that the U.S. "must drive development of appropriate technical standards" to enable AI adoption. We appreciate that OSTP Director nominee Michael Kratsios has publicly [acknowledged](#) the importance of U.S. leadership in setting AI standards.

As the global AI regulatory environment becomes increasingly complex and AI standards advance within international and regional fora, this is a critical moment for strong U.S. leadership in AI standards development. The National Institute for Standards and Technology (NIST) plays a key role in AI standards development as the lead agency coordinating federal engagement in the development and use of international standards. NIST and other agencies engage in standards development organizations, such as the International Organization for Standardization (ISO) and the International Electrotechnical Commission (IEC). NIST also leads important pre-standardization work, such as its leading AI Risk Management Framework.

We encourage the administration to support these critical elements of NIST's mission that leverage its core expertise in measurement science. In contrast to other countries, the federal government does not control or direct how standards are developed in the United States. Rather, the U.S. standards development system is voluntary, decentralized, and led by independent non-governmental bodies that convene industry, government, civil society, and academia on equal footing. This approach is widely recognized as a key factor in sustaining U.S. technology leadership. As international and regional standards bodies accelerate their AI standardization work, U.S. leadership in these venues will help ensure that global AI standards reflect U.S. values and the technical state-of-the-art pioneered by U.S. industry. We encourage the administration to invest in federal AI standards engagement as a key lever to advance U.S. AI leadership broadly.

Invest in the NIST AI Risk Management Framework

In 2019, the Trump administration [recognized](#) that trustworthy AI is underpinned by robust frameworks and technical standards. President Trump signed the *National AI Initiative Act*, which directed NIST to develop its voluntary AI Risk Management Framework (AI RMF) through an open, multi-stakeholder process. Released in 2023, the NIST AI RMF stands apart as a credible,

effective, and widely-accepted framework that represents a high water mark for U.S. federal AI governance. Amid an increasingly complex and dynamic AI regulatory environment both in the U.S. and around the world today, the NIST AI RMF has become a north star for science-based ground truth in AI risk management. Today it underpins AI risk management practices throughout the U.S. private sector and has shaped key policy, frameworks, and standards around the world.

Workday partnered with other stakeholders as an [early champion](#) for the creation of the NIST AI RMF in 2019. We [participated](#) in its development, implemented it as part of our AI development process, and have [publicly supported](#) the importance of NIST’s work and the adoption of the framework. Workday’s implementation of the AI RMF the subject was NIST’s first-ever [case study](#) highlighting industry adoption.

In light of its widespread success as a practical, workable, and influential risk management tool, we encourage the administration to continue investing in the NIST AI Framework. In particular, the administration should prioritize the Framework’s adoption and acceptance by U.S. trading partners, building on NIST’s previous success in internationalizing its influential Privacy and Cybersecurity Frameworks. While NIST has already translated the AI Framework into other languages, more should be done to expand its use by U.S. allies and incorporate its contents into ongoing international AI governance deliberations. Expanding the reach and utilization of the NIST AI Framework would bolster the competitiveness of the U.S. technology sector in foreign markets and strengthen U.S. AI leadership and innovation.

Chart a Path Forward on AI Governance

In his first term, President Trump anticipated AI’s strategic importance in his executive orders on [maintaining U.S. AI leadership](#) and [promoting the use of trustworthy AI](#) in the federal government. Despite significant technological advancements since these executive orders, their underlying principles and objectives have enduring relevance today. We recommend that, as the administration charts a path forward on AI policy, it leverages those principles as a means to advance U.S. AI leadership.

In particular, we recommend the administration implement the Office of Management and Budget’s “Guidance for Regulation of Artificial Intelligence Applications” ([M-21-06](#)). Published in November 2020 pursuant to [EO 13859](#), the OMB memo identified the policy considerations that should guide federal agencies’ regulatory and non-regulatory approaches to AI. In particular, it established ten Principles for the Stewardship of AI Applications: public trust in AI, public participation, scientific integrity and information quality, risk assessment and management, benefits and costs, flexibility, fairness and non-discrimination, disclosure and transparency, safety and security, and interagency coordination. While M-21-06 was published prior to the advancements in large language models that are driving much of today’s AI policy conversation, we believe these ten core principles remain a foundational starting point for any federal approach to AI policy.

As with the technology itself, since the 2019 and 2020 executive orders, the global AI regulatory environment too has evolved substantially. To the extent that the administration is considering

potential approaches to AI governance, we recommend focusing on those that drive federal AI adoption by encouraging common sense risk management practices. For example, the administration may consider encouraging agencies to adhere to the NIST AI RMF, a concept that garnered bipartisan interest in the 118th Congress through the *Federal Artificial Intelligence Risk Management Act of 2023* ([S.3205/H.R. 6936](#)). Agencies could apply the NIST Framework in instances in which AI is used to make, or is the principal basis in making, key decisions about employees or government services. This type of approach is both flexible and workable at scale, and would help drive federal AI adoption backed by the flagship U.S. AI framework.

Drive an AI-Powered, Skills-Based Approach to Talent

There is widespread consensus that workforce policy is a key element of effective AI policy. We agree that investing in the U.S. workforce is critical to achieving U.S. AI leadership. At the same time, we believe that AI itself holds enormous opportunities to drive shifts across the workforce—both in the AI field but also in sectors across the economy—by enabling skills-based approaches to talent at scale.

In 2020, President Trump issued [EO 13932](#) (Modernizing and Reforming the Assessment and Hiring of Federal Job Candidates), which has catalyzed a skills-based approach to talent across the federal government. Workday has long championed skills-based approaches to employment, which emphasize what a person can do or learn, instead of their credentials, as better indicators of capability and job performance. For example, Workday's 2025 [Global State of Skills Report](#) found that 81% of business leaders agree that adopting a skills-based approach improves productivity, innovation, and organizational agility. Similarly, a 2024 America First Policy Institute [report](#) found that “hiring for skills is five times more predictive of job performance than hiring based on degrees.”

While skills-based approaches to talent hold much promise, they are difficult to scale without the assistance of technology. Skills data is notoriously noisy and difficult to parse: a wide variety of words can be used to describe the same skill, and a number of different skills are often described with the same word. Fortunately, AI is [uniquely well-suited](#) to interpret, organize, and interrelate skills data to generate actionable insights for employers and workers. AI can process large amounts of data on occupational roles and responsibilities and develop skills ontologies, or vocabularies, that convert troves of skills data into meaningful information.

At Workday, we have been applying AI to this challenge for nearly a decade. Today, [Workday Skills Cloud](#) is the AI backbone of our skills-based employment solutions. Skills Cloud aligns the skills data in Workday to a common vocabulary and uses machine learning to map how different skills relate to each other and evolve over time, leveraging a blend of public data and data contributed by our customers that is tailored to their industry or mission. With Skills Cloud as the foundation, we provide a suite of human capital management tools that help our customers better understand what skills their workforces have and what skills they need, and help their employees grow their careers. For example:

- **Workday People Analytics** provides employers with real-time, personalized insights about the skills of their workforce, highlighting talent opportunities and risks tailored to their talent pool and industry.
- **Talent Marketplace** suggests short term growth opportunities for workers through rotations with other teams, helping them build career-relevant skills while meeting the needs of teams across the organization.
- **Career Hub** is a one-stop-shop where workers can find personalized career recommendations like learning content to grow their skills and suggested mentors based on their skills.

Workday has for years advocated for policy that supports skills-based approaches to talent and recognizes the importance of technology—particularly AI— in bringing these approaches to scale. In parallel, we have worked closely with Congress to support ongoing progress in leveraging skills in the federal government, as well as modernizing the federal labor data that power many skills-focused AI tools.

We urge the administration to build on Executive Order 13932 by focusing on moving from policy to practice, working to ensure federal agencies understand the skills within their workforces and the skills they need to achieve their missions. Both private and public sector employers are increasingly recognizing the benefits of a skills-based approach to talent, while also grappling with the challenges of implementing these strategies at scale. It is critical to ensure that agencies have timely access to AI tools that can effectively scale skills-based approaches to talent in the near-term in order to more effectively manage a skilled and adaptable federal workforce. Effectively leveraging AI to bolster the U.S. workforce—both in AI and other fields—is a fundamental component of advancing American AI leadership.

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